

Threat Hunt Report // Unauthorized R Usage

Detection of Unauthorized TOR Browser Installation and Use on Workstation:
ws-1650

Scenario:

Management suspects that some employees may be using TOR browsers to bypass network security controls because recent network logs show unusual encrypted traffic patterns and connections to known TOR entry nodes. Additionally, there have been anonymous reports of employees discussing ways to access restricted sites during work hours. The goal is to detect any TOR usage and analyze related security incidents to mitigate potential risks. If any use of TOR is found, notify management.

TOR-related IoC Discovery Plan:

1. Check **DeviceFileEvents** for any tor(.exe) or firefox(.exe) file events
 2. Check **DeviceProcessEvents** for any signs of installation or usage
 3. Check **DeviceNetworkEvents** for any signs of outgoing connections over known **TOR** ports
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Steps Taken:

Searched the **DeviceFileEvents** table for ANY file that had the string "tor" in it and discovered what looks like the user "**shari_higgenbottom**" downloaded a **tor installer**, did something that resulted in many tor-related files being copied to the desktop and the creation of a file called "**tor-shopping-list.txt**" on the desktop at **2026-05-04T21:01:10.9698279Z**. These events began at **2026-05-03T19:16:25.3417183Z**

Query to locate events:

```
DeviceFileEvents
| where DeviceName == "ws-1650"
| where InitiatingProcessAccountName == "shari_higgenbottom"
| where FileName contains "tor"
| order by Timestamp desc
| project Timestamp, DeviceName, ActionType, FileName, FolderPath, SHA256,
Account = InitiatingProcessAccountName
```

Results:

Results						
Query history Getting started						
1 of 26 selected						
Export Link to incident Take actions Show empty columns						
Filters: Add filter						
Timestamp	DeviceName	ActionType	FileName	FolderPath	SHA256	Account
May 6, 2026 5:59:05	ws-1650	FileCreated	tor-shopping-list.txt.lnk	C:\Users\shari_higgenbott	fa8615c7c9dce0eb5fb7	shari_h
May 6, 2026 5:59:05	ws-1650	FileRenamed	tor-shopping-list.txt	C:\Users\shari_higgenbott	150c6b7fd570ce8618b	shari_h
May 6, 2026 5:58:45	ws-1650	FileModified	storage.sqlite	C:\Users\shari_higgenbott	9cc5d21a0f3739ea958a	shari_h
May 6, 2026 5:58:44	ws-1650	FileModified	storage-sync-v2.sqlite	C:\Users\shari_higgenbott	c5c5ff086857d75f943f1	shari_h
May 4, 2026 4:01:10	ws-1650	FileCreated	tor-shopping-list.txt.lnk	C:\Users\shari_higgenbott	a462cee1c8dd1259949	shari_h
May 4, 2026 4:01:10	ws-1650	FileCreated	tor-shopping-list.txt	C:\Users\shari_higgenbott	150c6b7fd570ce8618b	shari_h
May 4, 2026 3:13:02	ws-1650	FileCreated	formhistory.sqlite	C:\Users\shari_higgenbott		shari_h
May 4, 2026 3:07:52	ws-1650	FileModified	storage.sqlite	C:\Users\shari_higgenbott	bff202afba5acffe6c12	shari_h
May 4, 2026 3:06:47	ws-1650	FileCreated	storage-sync-v2.sqlite	C:\Users\shari_higgenbott		shari_h
May 4, 2026 3:06:44	ws-1650	FileCreated	storage.sqlite	C:\Users\shari_higgenbott		shari_h
May 4, 2026 3:05:52	ws-1650	FileCreated	Tor Browser.lnk	C:\Users\shari_higgenbott	a5adad25ceb5833c41c	shari_h
May 4, 2026 3:05:47	ws-1650	FileCreated	tor.exe	C:\Users\shari_higgenbott	a028d058c4d49cf0df10	shari_h
May 4, 2026 3:05:47	ws-1650	FileCreated	tor.txt	C:\Users\shari_higgenbott	5dc29ea302cc75db6db	shari_h
May 4, 2026 3:05:47	ws-1650	FileCreated	Torbutton.txt	C:\Users\shari_higgenbott	73b2a217734a2b37ecc	shari_h
May 4, 2026 3:05:47	ws-1650	FileCreated	Tor-Launcher.txt	C:\Users\shari_higgenbott	d4fd98d01e1714e6b86	shari_h
May 4, 2026 3:03:06	ws-1650	FileRenamed	tor-browser-windows-x86_64-portable-15.0.11.exe	C:\Users\shari_higgenbott	3ae94669801d4c13700	shari_h
May 4, 2026 3:03:02	ws-1650	FileRenamed	tor-browser-windows-x86_64-portable-15.D5T-l	C:\Users\shari_higgenbott		shari_h
May 4, 2026 2:24:09	ws-1650	FileCreated	storage.sqlite	C:\Users\shari_higgenbott	be924050f85b3db6774	shari_h
May 3, 2026 7:36:26	ws-1650	FileModified	storage.sqlite	C:\Users\shari_higgenbott	a416d9f5bc15541de37	shari_h
May 3, 2026 2:16:30	ws-1650	FileRenamed	tor-browser-windows-x86_64-portable-15.0.11.exe	C:\Users\shari_higgenbott	3ae94669801d4c13700	shari_h
May 3, 2026 2:16:25	ws-1650	FileRenamed	tor-browser-windows-x86_64-portable-15.7PWx	C:\Users\shari_higgenbott		shari_h

Searched the **DeviceProcessEvents** table for any **ProcessCommandLine** that contained the string "**tor-browser-windows-x86_64-portable-15.0.11.exe**". At **2026-05-04T20:05:36.3830487Z**, employee account, **shari_higgenbottom** on the '**ws-1650**' device ran the file **tor-browser-windows-x86_64-portable-15.0.11.exe** from their Downloads folder, using a command that triggered a **silent installation**.

Query used to locate event:

```
DeviceProcessEvents
| where DeviceName == "ws-1650"
| where ProcessCommandLine contains
"tor-browser-windows-x86_64-portable-15.0.11.exe"
| project Timestamp, DeviceName, AccountName, FileName, FolderPath, SHA256,
ProcessCommandLine
```

Results:

Results

Query history

Getting started

Export

Show empty columns

1 item

Search

00:00.378

Low

Filters:

Add filter

Timestamp

DeviceName

AccountName

FileName

FolderPath

May 4, 2026 3:05:36 PM

ws-1650

shari_higgenbottom

tor-browser-windows-x86_64-portable-15.0.11.exe

C:\Users\shari_higgenbottom\Downloads\tor-brow

Timestamp

DeviceName

AccountName

FileName

FolderPath

SHA256

ProcessCommandLine

May 4, 2026 3:05:36 PM

ws-1650

shari_higgenbottom

tor-browser-windows-x86_64-portable-15.0.11.exe

C:\Users\shari_higgenbottom\Downloads\tor-browser-windows-x86_64-portable-15.0.11.exe

3ae94669801d4c1370066c2322eb3bd58a4e3cd063dab6670ea3eef286145e7

tor-browser-windows-x86_64-portable-15.0.11.exe /S

Searched the **DeviceProcessEvents** table for any indication that user "**shari_higgenbottom**" actually opened the **tor browser**. There was evidence that they did open it at **2026-05-04T20:06:43.6949055Z**. There were several other instances of **firefox.exe** (tor) as well as **tor.exe** spawned afterwards.

Query used to locate events:

```
DeviceProcessEvents
| where DeviceName == "ws-1650"
| where FileName has_any ("tor.exe", "firefox.exe", "tor-browser.exe")
| project Timestamp, DeviceName, AccountName, ActionType, FileName,
FolderPath, SHA256, ProcessCommandLine
| order by Timestamp desc
```

Results:

Results							
Query history							
Getting started							
Export							
Show empty columns							
Timestamp	DeviceName	AccountName	ActionType	FileName	FolderPath	SHA256	
May 6, 2026 5:57:50 PM	ws-1650	shari_higgenbottom	ProcessCreated	firefox.exe	C:\Program Files\Mozilla Firefox\firefox.exe	21b3b6e5fd42e3499cdf30bfa3bffd11b0dd3e17	
May 6, 2026 5:57:49 PM	ws-1650	shari_higgenbottom	ProcessCreated	firefox.exe	C:\Program Files\Mozilla Firefox\firefox.exe	21b3b6e5fd42e3499cdf30bfa3bffd11b0dd3e17	
May 6, 2026 5:57:49 PM	ws-1650	shari_higgenbottom	ProcessCreated	firefox.exe	C:\Program Files\Mozilla Firefox\firefox.exe	21b3b6e5fd42e3499cdf30bfa3bffd11b0dd3e17	
May 6, 2026 3:56:39 PM	ws-1650	shari_higgenbottom	ProcessCreated	firefox.exe	C:\Program Files\Mozilla Firefox\firefox.exe	21b3b6e5fd42e3499cdf30bfa3bffd11b0dd3e17	
May 6, 2026 3:56:39 PM	ws-1650	shari_higgenbottom	ProcessCreated	firefox.exe	C:\Program Files\Mozilla Firefox\firefox.exe	21b3b6e5fd42e3499cdf30bfa3bffd11b0dd3e17	
May 6, 2026 3:25:49 PM	ws-1650	shari_higgenbottom	ProcessCreated	firefox.exe	C:\Users\shari_higgenbottom\Desktop\Tor Browser\Browser\firefox.exe	cc24a3b8e51a8301f65fe06335ec65a95b9076d4	
May 6, 2026 3:25:45 PM	ws-1650	shari_higgenbottom	ProcessCreated	firefox.exe	C:\Users\shari_higgenbottom\Desktop\Tor Browser\Browser\firefox.exe	cc24a3b8e51a8301f65fe06335ec65a95b9076d4	
May 6, 2026 3:25:45 PM	ws-1650	shari_higgenbottom	ProcessCreated	firefox.exe	C:\Users\shari_higgenbottom\Desktop\Tor Browser\Browser\firefox.exe	cc24a3b8e51a8301f65fe06335ec65a95b9076d4	
May 6, 2026 3:25:42 PM	ws-1650	shari_higgenbottom	ProcessCreated	firefox.exe	C:\Users\shari_higgenbottom\Desktop\Tor Browser\Browser\firefox.exe	cc24a3b8e51a8301f65fe06335ec65a95b9076d4	
May 6, 2026 3:25:41 PM	ws-1650	shari_higgenbottom	ProcessCreated	firefox.exe	C:\Users\shari_higgenbottom\Desktop\Tor Browser\Browser\firefox.exe	cc24a3b8e51a8301f65fe06335ec65a95b9076d4	
May 6, 2026 3:25:41 PM	ws-1650	shari_higgenbottom	ProcessCreated	firefox.exe	C:\Users\shari_higgenbottom\Desktop\Tor Browser\Browser\firefox.exe	cc24a3b8e51a8301f65fe06335ec65a95b9076d4	
May 6, 2026 3:25:40 PM	ws-1650	shari_higgenbottom	ProcessCreated	firefox.exe	C:\Users\shari_higgenbottom\Desktop\Tor Browser\Browser\firefox.exe	cc24a3b8e51a8301f65fe06335ec65a95b9076d4	
May 6, 2026 3:25:40 PM	ws-1650	shari_higgenbottom	ProcessCreated	firefox.exe	C:\Users\shari_higgenbottom\Desktop\Tor Browser\Browser\firefox.exe	cc24a3b8e51a8301f65fe06335ec65a95b9076d4	
May 6, 2026 3:25:40 PM	ws-1650	shari_higgenbottom	ProcessCreated	tor.exe	C:\Users\shari_higgenbottom\Desktop\Tor Browser\Browser\TorBrowser\Tor\tor.exe	a028d058c4d49cfdcf10fe6069e4c8fe177d8996	
May 6, 2026 3:25:39 PM	ws-1650	shari_higgenbottom	ProcessCreated	firefox.exe	C:\Users\shari_higgenbottom\Desktop\Tor Browser\Browser\firefox.exe	cc24a3b8e51a8301f65fe06335ec65a95b9076d4	
May 6, 2026 3:25:36 PM	ws-1650	shari_higgenbottom	ProcessCreated	firefox.exe	C:\Users\shari_higgenbottom\Desktop\Tor Browser\Browser\firefox.exe	cc24a3b8e51a8301f65fe06335ec65a95b9076d4	
May 6, 2026 3:25:34 PM	ws-1650	shari_higgenbottom	ProcessCreated	firefox.exe	C:\Users\shari_higgenbottom\Desktop\Tor Browser\Browser\firefox.exe	cc24a3b8e51a8301f65fe06335ec65a95b9076d4	
May 6, 2026 1:03:01 PM	ws-1650	shari_higgenbottom	ProcessCreated	firefox.exe	C:\Program Files\Mozilla Firefox\firefox.exe	21b3b6e5fd42e3499cdf30bfa3bffd11b0dd3e17	
May 6, 2026 1:03:01 PM	ws-1650	shari_higgenbottom	ProcessCreated	firefox.exe	C:\Program Files\Mozilla Firefox\firefox.exe	21b3b6e5fd42e3499cdf30bfa3bffd11b0dd3e17	
May 6, 2026 1:02:58 PM	ws-1650	shari_higgenbottom	ProcessCreated	firefox.exe	C:\Program Files\Mozilla Firefox\firefox.exe	21b3b6e5fd42e3499cdf30bfa3bffd11b0dd3e17	
May 6, 2026 1:02:58 PM	ws-1650	shari_higgenbottom	ProcessCreated	firefox.exe	C:\Program Files\Mozilla Firefox\firefox.exe	21b3b6e5fd42e3499cdf30bfa3bffd11b0dd3e17	
May 6, 2026 1:02:58 PM	ws-1650	shari_higgenbottom	ProcessCreated	firefox.exe	C:\Program Files\Mozilla Firefox\firefox.exe	21b3b6e5fd42e3499cdf30bfa3bffd11b0dd3e17	

Results							
Query history							
Getting started							
May 4, 2026 3:06:43 PM	ws-1650	shari_higgenbottom	ProcessCreated	firefox.exe	C:\Users\shari_higgenbottom\Desktop\Tor Browser\Browser\firefox.exe	cc24a3b8e51a8301f65fe06335ec65a95b9076d4784dfb0ae0a6adac0f025bfaa	
Timestamp	May 4, 2026 3:06:43 PM						
DeviceName	ws-1650						
AccountName	shari_higgenbottom						
ActionType	ProcessCreated						
FileName	firefox.exe						
FolderPath	C:\Users\shari_higgenbottom\Desktop\Tor Browser\Browser\firefox.exe						
SHA256	cc24a3b8e51a8301f65fe06335ec65a95b9076d4784dfb0ae0a6adac0f025bfaa						
ProcessCommandLine	firefox.exe						

Searched the **DeviceNetworkEvents** table for any indication the tor browser was used to establish a connection using any of the known TOR port numbers. At **3:25 PM on May 6, 2026**, the account shari_higgenbottom on device ws-1650 **successfully established a connection** to remote IP 94.130.52.190 on port 9030. The connection was initiated by process **tor.exe**, located at C:\users\shari_higgenbottom\desktop\tor browser\browser\torbrowser\tor\tor.exe. There were a few other connections to sites over **port 443**.

Query used to locate events:

```
DeviceNetworkEvents
| where DeviceName == "ws-1650"
| where InitiatingProcessAccountName != "system"
| where RemotePort in (9001, 9030, 9040, 9050, 9051, 9150)
| project Timestamp, DeviceName, InitiatingProcessAccountName, ActionType,
RemoteIP, RemotePort, RemoteUrl, InitiatingProcessFileName,
InitiatingProcessFolderPath
```

Results:

Results Query history Getting started							
Export		Show empty columns		6 items		Search 00:01.460 Low	
Filters: Add filter							
Timestamp	DeviceName	InitiatingProcessAc...	ActionType	RemoteIP	RemotePort	RemoteUrl	
> May 6, 2026 3:25:48	ws-1650	shari_higgenbottom	ConnectionSuccess	(w) 127.0.0.1	9150		
> May 6, 2026 3:25:48	ws-1650		ConnectionAcknowledged	(w) 94.130.52.190	9030		
May 6, 2026 3:25:48	ws-1650	shari_higgenbottom	ConnectionSuccess	(w) 94.130.52.190	9030		
Timestamp		May 6, 2026 3:25:48 PM					
DeviceName		ws-1650					
InitiatingProcessAccountName		shari_higgenbottom					
ActionType		ConnectionSuccess					
RemoteIP		(w) 94.130.52.190					
RemotePort		9030					
InitiatingProcessFileName		tor.exe					
InitiatingProcessFolderPath		c:\users\shari_higgenbottom\desktop\tor browser\browser\torbrowser\tor\tor.exe					
> May 4, 2026 3:07:54	ws-1650		ConnectionAcknowledged	(w) 94.130.52.190	9030		

Chronological Events:

1. File Download – TOR Installer

- **Timestamp:** 2026-05-03T19:16:25.3417183Z
- **Event:** The account shari_higgenbottom on device ws-1650 downloaded a file named tor-browser-windows-x86_64-portable-15.0.11.exe to the Downloads folder.
- **Action:** File download detected.
- **File Path:**
C:\Users\shari_higgenbottom\Downloads\tor-browser-windows-x86_64-portable-15.0.11.exe

2. Process Execution – TOR Browser Installation

- **Timestamp:** 2026-05-04T20:05:36.3830487Z

- **Event:** The account shari_higgenbottom executed tor-browser-windows-x86_64-portable-15.0.11.exe in silent mode, initiating a background installation of the TOR Browser.
- **Action:** Process creation detected.
- **Command:** tor-browser-windows-x86_64-portable-15.0.11.exe /S
- **File Path:**
C:\Users\shari_higgenbottom\Downloads\tor-browser-windows-x86_64-portable-15.0.11.exe

3. Process Execution – TOR Browser Launch

- **Timestamp:** 2026-05-04T20:06:43.6949055Z
- **Event:** The account shari_higgenbottom opened the TOR browser. Subsequent processes associated with TOR browser including firefox.exe and tor.exe were also created, indicating the browser launched successfully.
- **Action:** Process creation of TOR browser-related executables detected.
- **File Path:** C:\Users\shari_higgenbottom\Desktop\Tor Browser\Browser\TorBrowser\Tor\tor.exe

4. Network Connection – TOR Network

- **Timestamp:** 2026-05-06T15:25:48Z
- **Event:** The account shari_higgenbottom on device ws-1650 successfully established a connection to remote IP 94.130.52.190 on port 9030 using tor.exe, confirming TOR browser network activity.
- **Action:** Connection success.
- **Process:** tor.exe
- **File Path:** C:\users\shari_higgenbottom\desktop\tor browser\browser\torbrowser\tor\tor.exe

5. File Creation – TOR Shopping List

- **Timestamp:** 2026-05-04T21:01:10.9698279Z
- **Event:** The account shari_higgenbottom created a file named tor-shopping-list.txt on the desktop, potentially indicating notes related to TOR browser activity.
- **Action:** File creation detected.
- **File Path:** C:\Users\shari_higgenbottom\Desktop\tor-shopping-list.txt

Summary:

The account, "shari_higgenbottom" on the "ws-1650" device initiated and completed the installation of the **TOR browser**. They proceeded to launch the browser, establish connections within the TOR network, and created various files related to TOR on their desktop, including a file named **tor-shopping-list.txt**. This sequence of activities indicates that the user actively installed, configured, and used the **TOR browser**, likely for anonymous browsing purposes, with possible documentation in the form of the "shopping list" file. The full sequence from download to silent install to active network connections confirms intentional installation and use rather than accidental execution.

Response Taken:

TOR usage was confirmed on endpoint **ws-1650**. The device was isolated and the user's direct manager was notified.